the storm in your bright eyes

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/24838219.

Rating:
Mature

Archive Warning:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

Categories:
F/F, F/M

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Minor or Background Relationship(s), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), Perfuma/Scorpia (She-Ra), Mermista/Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Catra/Lonnie (She-Ra)

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Additional Tags:
Fluff, Angst with a Happy Ending, Alternate Universe - Modern Setting, Alternate Universe - College/University, Alternate Universe - Roommates/Housemates, another roommates au nobody asked for, Lesbian Catra (She-Ra), Lesbian Adora (She-Ra), Mentions of Death, sw is dead, catra is rich, jock!Adora, cheerleader!catra, swimmer!catra, Alternate Universe - Sports, Human Catra (She-Ra), sorry y'all, reuniting with your childhood friend who you used to have a crush on, yeah - Freeform, Catra (She-Ra) Needs a Hug, Mentions of Therapy, mentions of drinking, Jealous Adora (She-Ra), Implied Sexual Content, its just the waitress okay, Ambiguous/Open Ending

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Collections:
Himmelslieds Collection of Catradora Goodness

Stats:
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by catravol

Summary

After two years of radio silence, Catra and Adora find themselves in a complicated relationship, when they find out that they're gonna share a dorm for the entirety of their freshman year at BMU.

or, roommates au + college au with catradora because i love them.

Notes

hi!!
this is my first work in over five years, that's... pretty wild, huh.
anyways, i'm still not ever these two being canon like i love my useless lesbians sm... and i needed to add some sports au in here because. well. i have some unrepressed feelings abt certain sports that i need to get out :))
also this is only tagged mature because i'm paranoid tyvm

if you find any mistakes please please please don't hesitate to tell!! while i hate saying that, english is not my first language so i might have missed some.

fic title + ch1 title is from city lights by blanche!

See the end of the work for more notes

all alone in the flame of doubt

Etheria was busy, even at night. People swarmed the streets; some going home from work and some hanging out with their friends.

Catra frowned. Friends. What a crazy, unbelievable concept.

Friends? That don't leave? How funny, never could happen to me.

She shook her head and went back inside her hotel room. Catra arrived to Etheria just this afternoon with all of her stuff. She was supposed to attend Horde University, but had a quick change of heart after her mother's death.

Catra didn't like to dwell on her past; it was always tiring. She didn't want to explain anything to anyone about it. All Catra wanted to do was live in the moment, which is why she was here right now - or at least that's how her therapist explained her sudden change of heart to her.

In *Etheria* . About to move into the *Brightmoon University* dorms.

It still felt surreal, but it was her reality now. She left everything behind to start a new life with her mother's money. It didn't matter to her that some of it was dirty - it's not like she took care of her own finances. Both her and her mother had someone to take care of it, while they only spend the money accordingly.

Fuck her mother, though.

Catra decided to tuck in for the night; she'll have enough time to explore the city once she's officially settled in. For now, she was exhausted and wanted to sleep.

She'll deal with her problems tomorrow - one of them being her future roommate. She really didn't mean to know who it was, but Eloise - or, as she preferred, Entrapta - just had to hack into the

file that contained the room numbers and its future residents. One familiar name was stuck in her head since then.

Building 8, Floor 5, Room 517.

Cathrina Weaver, Adora Grayskull.

It couldn't be possible. She managed to move on since the blonde's leaving and here she was. In Etheria, of all places. Going to Brightmoon, of all universities. Sharing a room with her, out of how many freshmens there were that year. It fucking *sucked* .

Catra tossed and turned in her hotel bed, unable to fall asleep. Thoughts of Adora filled her head and she couldn't ignore them. Finally, she decided to get up and went over to one of her suitcases - it was actually the only one she took out of her colorado red Jeep Renegade that was parked in the underground parking. After a moment of going through her stuff, she found what she was looking for.

One of the things that thing that dared to call herself my mother was good for.

The sleeping pills, produced by one of the companies her mother was the CEO of, were her best friends. She often had troubles sleeping through the entirety of the night, so one day she snuck into Shyanne Weaver's office just to steal some of hers. Of course, it didn't go unnoticed by her mother figure, but she didn't comment on it. That's how their relationship worked - less talking equaled less arguing. Well, until her death. But that wasn't something she was ready to think about just yet.

Catra didn't like to dwell on her past. She got herself a glass of water from her bathroom, took the pills and laid down. Sleep came easily after that.

Adora was excited.

No, excited was undermining it. She was *thrilled* .

She finally did it. She got into her dream University, on a scholarship nonetheless. She's been working for it during her last two years of High School and all her hard work had finally paid off.

Sure, she was *elevated* .

The magazine that sat on the dresser of her hotel room couldn't ruin it, despite its front page glaring at her from across the room.

BREAKING NEWS: Shyanne Weaver, CEO of several medical companies, dead due to an unexpected heart attack. Find out more on Page 3.

Adora couldn't believe her eyes when she first saw the headline. Shyanne Weaver was a person she was’t, well, *close* to during her childhood. She was close with her daughter, though. And that had to count for something, *right?*

Her and Cathrina, or *Catra* , as she preferred, were inseparable up until the end of their sophomore year of High School. That was when everything went to shit - they started arguing a lot, up till Adora moved and changed schools. Ever since then, the two of them hadn't had any type of contact.

Adora still remembered her phone number by heart.

Even if she *somehow* didn't, it's not like finding a way to contact Catra was hard. Thanks to her wealthy mother, Catra had quite the following on social media. Adora, of course, knew all her handles.

Not like she was obsessed or something. She just liked to check up on her old friend. That was it. At least, that's what she told herself. Glimmer and Bow disagreed.

At the thought of her friends, Adora smiled. She missed them dearly, but they'd reunite tomorrow, after not seeing each other for the entirety of the summer vacation. Glimmer spent the last two months helping out her aunt Casta at her job as an interior designer, while Bow decided to spend his last summer before university with his dads at their library, sorting through some older books.

Her fingers moved involuntary to the instagram icon and clicked on it. Immediately, she was flooded with notifications - she sometimes forgot how being the star player of a soccer team got her some fans.

Adora didn’t really like the fame. She preferred keeping to herself and having a small group of friends; not some fakes who would follow her around school just to have their five minutes of fame, because of their relation to her.

Shit. I should probably stop thinking about my High School years, they’re done and over with. Get a grip, Adora.

As fast as she could, in case she decided to chicken out, she clicked the explore page and quickly typed *clawtra* in the search engine. The name was so fucking *stupid* and *dumb* and all the things Catra *wasn’t* , but it somehow fit her perfectly.

There she was. Her childhood best friend. Her sexual awakening - because, yes, Adora was a huge lesbian. So what if Catra helped her with that, it didn't matter now. *She* didn’t matter now, or that’s what her brain kept telling her..

She checked her most recent picture and almost had a heart attack. In the picture was, obviously, Catra, dressed in an unbuttoned black shirt with a laced red bralette underneath and some black high waisted shorts. She was standing on a balcony with a glass of what she could only assume was some expensive brand of red wine. What shocked her the most though, was the view behind. It was familiar.

Etheria.

Even if she didn't recognize the city she lived in now and visited so many times before - mostly because of her troubles with University applications - the caption made it extremely clean about her childhood friend’s whereabouts.

bu im comin for ya

She was coming to Brightmoon University; so was Adora. It felt surreal. After years of conflict, they could finally reconnect. Could being the keyword - how was she supposed to know what Catra was majoring in or which house she was staying in. For all she knew, they would never see each other throughout the four years. Well, unless the brunette was still a cheerleader. That'd make things more interesting, since Adora was already accepted into Brightmoon’s main soccer team. This way, they'd have to see each other, at least during practice. This was her chance to fix things.

She didn't dare to hope. Not after what happened two years earlier. But she could dream, couldn't she?

“What do you mean you’re leaving?” asked sixteen year old Catra, looking her best friend dead in the eye. They just came back from the end-of-year party that seniors hosted every year, finally finished with their sophomore year.

“Catra, I’m… I’m sorry. I got a soccer scholarship at Salineas High School and couldn’t say no,” Adora took a deep breath. She could see tears forming in Catras eyes, but she had to tell her everything. It was hard for her too and she couldn’t keep it from the most important person in her life any longer. “This is a huge opportunity for me and my career. My moms already bought a house there.”

Something shifted then. The tears from brunettes eyes disappeared, the only thing visible in the mismatched eyes was anger. Anger at her.

“Wow, so you were planning on leaving and didn’t even plan on telling me? Figures you didn’t care about me enough. Should’ve figured that out a long time ago, to be honest,” Catra sighed, glaring at the blonde.

“You know it isn’t true!” Adora yelled. “Of course I care about you! You’re the most important person in my life - you always has been!”

Catra just shook her head. “You say that now. Where was that attitude everytime I needed support from you? Nowhere to be found, huh?”

“Catra, please… we don’t have to keep arguing. I’m leaving tomorrow morning, just, please… let me spend my last night with you.” she begged at the verge of crying.

“Adora. You made your choice. I’m making mine now. Goodbye, get out of my life. Forever, if you could,” with these words, Catra left the one she once loved on the floor, crying.

Adora sighed. She exited the picture and decided to take a quick look at the others. While she knew she'd recognize Catra anywhere, she wanted to know what her *"friend"* was up to.

While scrolling, a few pictures caught her attention. The first being of some swimming competition, she assumed. Catra was standing proud on the top of the podium, in a simple red one-piece with a gold medal around her neck.

So, she finally decided to take up swimming. I thought she hated the water.

The second post that got Adora to gawk her eyes out, was a simple picture of Catra and a *very* muscular woman who had her arm around the smaller girl. She couldn't help the jealousy that started bubbling up inside her. They looked so… *happy.* Despite the picture looking romantic-like, the caption made everything clear.

out with my bestie. @perflo better watch out or imma steal ur girl

Adora released the breath she didn't realize she was holding. There was nothing to be jealous about.

Wait a minute; why was she even jealous? Catra and her hadn't talked in two years, a lot had changed since then. Adora moved

on and Catra probably did too. She had no right to be jealous of her, that much was made clear to her during one of her therapy sessions. But still, seeing Catra with someone else, another woman made Adora uncomfortable. But… why?

Oh no.

She was in way too deep.

The next morning found Catra driving her jeep into Brightmoons underground parking, because apparently they had one. *Go figure* . When she *finally* found a parking spot, someone was already there to help her with her stuff.

"Miss, could I see your ID?" asked the man. She showed him the ID she got the day earlier and got out of the car. "Thank you, miss. Here's a baggage carousel for your bags, once you have finished unpacking just leave it in front of your room," with that, the man left leaving Catra alone with her baggage and the carousel for her stuff. She sighed. *This is gonna take a while, isn't it.*

She tried getting there as early as possible - her move-in time was at 8 a.m., the earliest there was. She could only hope Adora's time wasn't the same as hers, or she would be screwed.

Of course she was screwed.

When she got to her room, room 517, the door was already opened and she could hear noise from the inside. *As if my day couldn't get any worse.* She took a deep breath. In and out. Just like her therapist asked of her. She decided to start heading towards the door and just as she was about to show up at the doorstep, someone came running out of the room. They ended bumping into her, which made them both fall over to the floor.

"Watch where you're fucking goi-," the words died down Catra's throat as soon as they left it. On top of her, *straddling her* , was the one and only Adora Grayskull. "Oh."

Oh was an understatement of the century.

"Holy shit, Catra?" Adora looked bewildered. Who could blame her, it's not everyday you bump into your first crush just outside your dorm. "What are you doing here? Okay, no. That's a stupid question, I'm so-"

"Could you maybe, just maybe, get off me first? It's kinda hard to breathe, you stupid jock," interrupted Catra, staring into Adora's clear blue eyes. No matter what she said, she missed them terribly. Adora's *perfectly* white face was suddenly accompanied by a pink blush, as the girl quickly stood up and reached out a hand to help her *friend? ex-friend?* out.

Catra, just as quickly, got up without Adora's help. The blonde frowned. She knew Catra wouldn't be exactly friendly with her, but it was just basic manners. Her thoughts got interrupted when she finally took a good look at her childhood friend and *god* , did she not disappoint. The latina was dressed in a plain, sleeveless black crop top that was paired with some ripped pair of black jeans. She had her long, wild, dark bronze hair up in a ponytail with some strands around her face that probably fell out during their little encounter. The most beautiful of all, though, were her mesmerizing eyes - one golden, one ocean blue. Adora felt herself falling.

Meanwhile, the girl in question wasn't much better off either. Adora had really changed, like, a lot. The most noticeable thing being her muscles on display. *Holy fuck, she's ripped;* Catra's thoughts betrayed her once again - she didn't want to think of her childhood best friend like that. Not again. The blonde was dressed in a white tank top, like she wanted people to see how good she looked. It was tucked in some black shorts from a company she didn't recognize, but they looked good on her; they made her muscular legs even easier to admire. Her blue eyes were still as blue as she remembered - if that even made any sense. Her blonde hair was up in her signature ponytail, but the little hair poof she used to do when she was younger was gone. She looked really good, Catra had to admit. *Gorgeous* , even, but that's not something she was ready to say yet.

"Uh, okay. Hi," Adora mumbled, still hypnotized by the eyes of her companion, after a long moment of silence.

Catra *almost* cracked a small smile. but what came out instead was a grimace. "Yes, hi. Can you move, so I can get in? That'd be nice."

"Wait, what's your room number?" Adora's distraught face would almost make Catra laugh out loud, if they weren't still at odds. Catra just stared at her as if she grew another head and pointed at the *517* engraved by the doors. "Wait, but that's my room."

"Yeah, idiot. We're roommates. Get over it. Can I get into the room now?" Catra said, very not over it despite how hard she tried to hide it. Earlier, she decided that she should try to be as civil as possible, while also avoiding the blonde as much as possible. Turns out it'd be harder than Catra thought at first. After another moment of silence, they heard some commotion from the room and, suddenly, two heads peeked out of the doorframe.

"Adora, what's going on?" asked a pink haired short girl. Catra immediately made a mental note of how sparkly her hair was; Sparkles it was.

“Hey Sparkles and whatever your name is, can you let me into my room since this idiot won’t?” the latina said, and, instead of waiting for an answer, pushed her way into the room with her baggage.

“Hey!” the boy in a crop top said - wow, Catra had to applaud his clothing choices; he rocked it. Not like she would admit it out loud - they were Adora’s friends after all, which meant they were probably as goody two shoes and as dumb as her. “A bit more respectful, how about that?”

Catra could see he was trying to be mean, but couldn’t. *What a softie.* Even if he didn’t succeed, his words still stung. They reminded Catra of *her* and all the words *she* used to say to her. In a moment, the ghost of a smile on her lips disappeared and turned into a scowl. “You don’t have any rights to say that to me. Now move, I need to get this over with quick,” she said as she started pulling her luggage into the room. “Thanks.”

While the room wasn’t as spacious as her apartment back in Fright, it wasn’t as small as she thought it’d be. They had their own *fucking* kitchen for fuck’s sake, that *had* to count for something. It wasn’t big, just a stovetop with a few cabinets, but it was enough for two college students she supposed. The cabinets were pearl white with black accents with marble on top, while the stovetop was black - it looked modern, but she wouldn’t bet her money on it. To the right of her there were two doors - she assumed one of them was the bathroom and the other the bedroom. As she opened the first door, just for a quick peek, she concluded that she was indeed correct. It was a pretty spacious bathroom for college standards. It had a marble floor - *why was everything at Brightmoon so fancy* - and the walls were decorated with white tiles. Everything was just so, so *bright* , that Catra’s eyes burned. Besides that, everything was pretty normal - a shower that could also be used as a bath, a sink and a toilet. In the shower area, there were some empty shelves and a small medical kit. Catra assumed another one was in the kitchen, but didn’t bother going back to check.

The second door was were the bedroom was. It was the most spacious room of them all. It had two single beds - *thank god* , she didn’t wanna sleep in bunks with Adora of all people - that were on opposite ends of the room; between them was a window that overlooked one of the basketball courts. In distance, she could see the swimming centre. As soon as she saw it, she decided she needed to visit it as soon as she was done with settling in - which, probably, wouldn’t happen for a few days, but it was fine. Swimming practice could wait.

The bed to the left of the window was already occupied with a bunch of suitcases, so she took the one to the right. Besides the beds, there was also a wardrobe for each of them. Catra decided she’ll take a look inside later, since she was exhausted and still had to get her ass outside in- she checked her phone.

8:32 am.

She still had 20 more minutes till she had to go down and meet Scarlett. They decided to meet at some café so the younger girl could pick up something from the white-haired sophomore. Scorpia - it’s her nickname from high school, but it stuck - has been her rock ever since they met during Catra’s first day of junior year. Scarlett was this cool senior who a lot of younger kids feared, but at heart she was just a sweetheart. She loved hugs and cherished her friends dearly. *Sometimes too dearly.* They even tried dating at some point, but it didn’t work out. Scorpia herself was now in a happy relationship with some biology major at Brightmoon, Catra never had a chance to meet her.

“Oh my god, Wildcat! Long time no see,” was the first thing she heard while walking into the seemingly empty café. She looked over at the overly enthusiastic woman and let a small smile slip onto her face after a seemingly never ending tiring morning. They haven’t seen each other since Catra’s graduation, so the tall woman’s enthusiasm wasn’t surprising. “Last time I saw you, you were sporting that valedictorian look and now look at you! All grown up, in college! I might start crying.”

Catra started walking over to her best friend, while taking a look at her glamorous attire. She was sporting a black leather jacket with a white t-shirt underneath it that was hanging loosely on her muscular body. Her face was fully covered with some heavy make up, from the looks of it. Catra, who didn’t know much about make up herself, couldn’t really tell what Scorpia’s eye look was, but it looked cool to her. It was a mix of reds and pinks, which really suited the white haired woman.

“Scorp, stop it. You won’t cry, we both know that - that make up must have taken way too long for you to ruin it,” Catra took a deep breath while taking a seat besides her best friend, “besides, we’ve been texting everyday. Don’t act like you haven’t heard from me in years.”

Right in that moment, Scorpia enveloped her in one of her signature hugs. It was breathtaking - quite literally. Catra couldn’t help but smile at the female, she hasn’t changed at all. All Catra could do was melt into her embrace. After a moment, she finally let her go.

“Okay, while it’d be nice to catch up, I still have to start unpacking and you have a brunch date to go on and I don’t think you want to be late for that,” Catra smirked, while Scorpia blushed. Relationship stuff still made her a mess, but she was working on it. The same couldn’t be said for Catra.

Scorpia was about to walk out, when suddenly she turned around. “Wait! Entrapta said something about Adora being your roommate yesterday, right? I know you haven’t told me much about her, but

I know she means a lot to you and that with your nature, you'll do nothing about it," Scorpia took a deep breath, while Catra was looking at her bewildered. *Stupid Eloise and her stupid tech.* "You should talk it out, Wildcat. Give yourself a moment to think things through before, though. And after… let yourself heal. I wanna see you happy."

With that and one final smile, Scorpia left.

Catra was still shocked. *How did she know so much about my feelings, it's like she talked with my previous therapist.* But she knew she didn't. Scorpia wouldn't pry, she's not that kind of person. She just understood her. Catra quickly looked at the table where they both at just few minutes earlier. There was an unfinished coffee there - *Scorp could never finish a coffee in her life, too much caffeine* - but also a set of keys. Catra almost mentally slapped herself.

Of course she forgot about why she came here in the first place, all because of some stupid conversation. She looked at the seat where Scorpia was seated and noticed her helmet. *Thank god she didn't forget it again.*

Last time she asked Scorpia to get her bike for her was after her graduation party. She wasn't planning on drinking, but push came to shove and she ended up tipsy and unable to drive herself back home. Luckily, Scorpia was in Fright to celebrate with her and she didn't like alcohol at all, so she drove her home and took her bike with her. After ten hours of sleep and a mild headache, she remembered the night before and called Scorpia to drive her bike to her house. Of course, Scorpia being herself couldn't really drive a motorcycle, she just attached it to her car - *I still don't know how that works* - but she forgot about her helmet, so Catra - even if she wanted to - couldn't leave her house. Not like she had to exactly, but her foster mother decided that it'd be *fun* to spend some time with her daughter before she leaves for college. She didn't get to, because Catra moved out as soon as summer started to her own apartment leaving her ever absent mother alone to die two months later.

Catra took her helmet and keys and went out to the parking lot, where she noticed her baby. She missed riding a lot - her jeep was great, especially for moving, but it didn't give her the adrenaline rush she needed.

She thought about Scorpia's words again. Talk to Adora? She guessed she could do that, but it'd be hard. Maybe taking her friend's advice wasn't too bad - she could take a ride and go somewhere, just to think. Catra knew she couldn't blame her friend completely for leaving, she was at fault too. That was something her therapist taught her, after a bad panic attack mid-way through her junior year.

She sat herself on the bike and put her helmet on. Starting the engine, it felt like coming home for her.

Catra didn't like to dwell on her past.

Adora felt herself sigh. Of fucking course her roommate just had to be her childhood best friend, whom she ran away from two years earlier.

Well, maybe running away isn't a great phase. But that's what it essentially felt like, two years later.

She ran her hands through her medium, blonde hair - it was one of her nervous ticks. Who could blame her, it's not everyday you reunite with your crush. Yes, *crush* . Not *ex-crush* . When Adora saw Catra again, it was like her heart started beating again and something bloomed inside her chest. She thought she'd never see

her again, maybe in passing. But being *roommates* ? She thanked whatever god was out there for her chance at rekindling things with Catra.

Adora took a deep breath and looked around ~~her~~ their bedroom. It was empty - well, besides all of their suitcases and other necessities - and she finally had some time to think about things. Glimmer and Bow left a few minutes earlier, both to go unpack their own things. The former was already complaining about being roommates with the former captain of Salineas swimming team, Meri - or, as they all decided to call her, Mermista - and the fact that she'd have to deal with the swimmer's boyfriend all the time. Bow, who was roommates with said boyfriend, just offered her to spend time at his dorm, so Mermista can spend time with her *love* .

The blonde laughed. Bow could be really corny at times, but they both still loved him - Glimmer definitely more than her, but it was expected, considering that they've been dating for the past year. It wasn't tiring third-wheeling them, no matter what some people might say. They always had fun together.

I'm starting to think about the wrong thing again. I really need to hit the gym.

She decided to leave unpacking for later and go out. After all, she was now in college and living on her own, technically. She could do whatever she wanted to do, as long as it wasn't anything illegal. It felt like a breath of fresh air - as much as she loved her moms, they could be down right overbearing at times.

I need to stop thinking about them. I'm on my own now. Like a lone wolf- no. Let's not joke around.

Checking the time, Adora decided to just take her already packed gym bag and some ear plugs and headed out. It was only nearing midday, but she already had enough emotions to last her the entire semester. She really needed some time to cool off from Catra and hers morning meeting. Everytime she thought of it, her

head became a mess and her face became red. Adora wasn't checking her out back then - not at all. It wasn't wrong of her to admire beauty of nature, right? *Right?*

She was head over heels.

Without breaking a sweat, Adora jogged to the closest gym that Google Maps showed her and entered. At the reception sat a woman in, probably, her early 30s. She didn't look past forty, though, Adora concluded.

"Hello, this is the Brightmoon official gym, only for our students. May I have your ID?" she asked politely. Adora quickly fished out her ID from the pocket of her sweats - she ended up changing from her previous clothes to something more comfortable after Glimmer and Bow left. She handed it over to the receptionists who scanned it.

After a moment, she heard the woman speak again. "Welcome, the locker room is to your right, and if you go through the other door in it, you'll end up at the gym area. Have a good time and please do not ruin anything, as it will be taken from your scholarship funds, miss Grayskull."

Adora quickly nodded, took her ID back and headed to the locker room, where she changed into some black leggins and a white crop top she stole from Bow few months earlier. Sighing, she entered the gym area. Immediately, she saw some punching bags. *Perfect.*

She came over to the bags and started punching. Adora was always the "punch your feelings out" person, so this wasn't anything new to her. With that, though, all her feelings came back. How hot and bothered she was this morning after seeing Catra.

Adora kicked the bag harder. How her childhood best friend still had this kind of effect on her was a true mystery to her, though it really shouldn't be one. She thought she had finally moved on

past her feelings, but she should've known that she'd never be truly happy without Catra.

Why is thinking about feelings so hard. Ugh. I need a distraction.

She quickly ran over to the locker room to fish out her ear plugs and her phone. After putting them in her ear, she decided to put on some music.

Taylor Swift sounds so good right now.

Immediately after the thought came over her, she put on reputation and came back to - now her favorite - punching bag. The next few minutes her thoughts were flooded with music, so she just focused on the task at hand - getting some work out done. She could deal with her feelings later.

Don't blame me; love made me crazy.

No she couldn't. She quickly turned down the music and decided to actually start thinking before she drove herself crazy. Procrastination was a thing Adora hated, but found herself doing more often than not after a certain incident in her senior year, when she pulled three all nighters in a row, because she wasn't happy with her history project. *The fact that she got into Brightmoon as a history major was still unbelievable to her.*

Anyways, Catra time.

She always thought she wasn't good enough for Catra and, after some long therapy sessions the year before, she knew that the other girl probably felt it was the other way around. Adora really wanted to make it up to her, but didn't know how without her *hero complex* butting in, as her therapist had called it. At first, Adora thought it was stupid - she just wanted to help everyone and be nice; so what if she had to make some sacrifices for that? As long as the others were happy, Adora was happy. Apparently, that was a toxic mindset she had to get rid of - and she's been working on it, *really!* It was just super difficult.

Back to Catra. She loved her; she still does.

Adora was completely in love with Cathrina Weaver and honestly? *She was more than okay with that.*

Coming to terms with her feelings is hard, she decided. Adora wasn't really big on feelings - they often made things awkward and uncomfortable; more often than not, she was the one who had to make it fiddly by not reciprocating someone's feelings. But for Catra? It was worth it, she determined. Adora would move mountains if it meant she could make things right with her - and that was what she was planning on.

Catra really needed a fucking drink.

After spending some time at a lake she had never visited before, Catra was bored. For the last few hours, she let her mind wander to what could've been if she talked things out with Adora and-

And if Adora wanted her back.

Of course, that was impossible. Despite what her therapist and Scorpia always told her, she knew she unlovable. That's what her shitty family taught her. She was never good enough. She couldn't do anything right. Catra always felt like second best to Adora - heck, even her mother liked Adora more and she only met her a handful of times, since Shyanne Weaver preferred spending her time in her - now Catra's - beach house in Salineas instead of at home, with her daughter.

Well, at least the beach house might be useful in the future. I don't know about my other properties, though. Catra thought about all the other properties she inherited - her mother was always stress spending and she developed the same habit. That's why the first thing she did after getting all the money in her bank accounts was to hire an actual financist that had worked with her mother in the past. Even with that though, she loved spending money on useless stuff when she needed to unwind. It was a coping mechanism, she explained to anyone who asked.

Meeting Adora again made her want to suddenly spend a lot of money. *To the bar it was.*

She turned on her phone just to see a bunch of instagram and twitter notifications. She decided to check them later and, instead, went for Google Maps, since she didn't know any bars in Etheria yet. *Yet.*

After a quick search, she found one just one kilometer away from her dorm building. It was only four p.m. at the time, but Catra was longing for an evening of freedom. Since she knew she'd probably drink too much, she needed to bring her bike back first, though. Catra really hoped Adora wouldn't be there.

She wasn't. She wasn't there. The dorm was as empty as she remembered, not counting all the stuff that still needed to be unpacked.

I should probably stay and start unpacking instead of drinking. Oh, fuck my life.

Catra really needed to become a responsible adult. This was a good start, she decided - she opted out of drinking and started unpacking. The latina opened the wardrobe and the first thing Catra was met with was some dust. She immediately started sneezing like crazy.

Of fucking course these haven't been cleaned in weeks. Just my luck. I'll do this later.

Instead, she decided to set up her bed. She got rid of her swimming bag, which was the only thing on the skeleton of a bed, and started by getting the mattress dressed in some clean sheets.

After thirty minutes of hard work, the bed was done. Catra decided on something simple, but on edge - just like her. Her sheets were black, while her pillows ranged from black to crimson red with one standing out between them - it was neon green small pillow that her friend, DT, from Horde's swimming team had gave her. Despite not being entirely sure whether they actually liked her or not, she treasured the thing. She could always get what she wanted with the money she had, but she never got something just out of good will. It was kinda cute, but you wouldn't hear her say that out loud. She also covered the bed with some decorative pillows that she could hide inside a small drawer at the bottom of the bed alongside some other things.

Satisfied with the bed, Catra moved on to the bathroom. After opening it, she could see that Adora already started unpacking some things before leaving as well. All of the blonde's toiletries were already on the sink and on the shelf in the shower. After setting her toothbrush and toothpaste on the sink, Catra went to showering area and immediately sighed. Of course the shelf was a fucking high shelf.

I am now re-considering going to Brightmoon instead of Horde. At least there I knew that they didn't have high shelves.

After finally coming home from the gym, Adora wasn't expecting the first thing she'd see to be the door to the bathroom opened and to see Catra struggling to put something on the shower shelf. She quietly chuckled to herself.

She hasn't grown an inch.

Adora, in all of her 5'6 glory, decided to take mercy on her new roommate and quickly went over to her. Before she could even utter a word, though, she was interrupted.

"Hey, Adora," said Catra without even turning around and Adora almost had a heart attack right there.

"How did you know it was me? It could literally be anyone, like a burglar or something," she rambled, embarrassed for her behavior, while the brunette just looked at her with an empty look in her eyes.

"I know your footsteps. Anyways, can you help me? I know it's the only thing you want to do with me and that's fine."

If she said it any faster, it'd go by Adora's ears, but she caught Catra's words just in time. "Wait, what do you mean that's the only thing I want to do with you? When have I ever said that?"

"You didn't need to," left Catra's mouth. "You made it clear enough when you moved to Salineas. Now, help me with this stuff before I go feral here."

"No!" Adora quickly yelled, which earned her a questioning glance from the smaller woman. "I mean, yes I'll help you, but… You know I never meant to leave *you* , right?" she took the things out of Catra's hands, which were pretty small (her nails were still as

sharp and black as ever, though) and started putting them on the left side of the shelf, since her things already occupied the right side. “We could’ve stayed in contact, you know. Plus, I’m pretty sure you have a beach house in Salineas, so you could’ve come visit at anyti-”

“Why would I bother? I was always a distraction in your perfect life, you didn’t need me,” after that, the latina left the bathroom without even looking back. Adora looked at her go with a sad glint in her eyes. Catra disappeared from her line of sight of a line, but reappeared a moment later with a bag in her hands and with her leather jacket on. She looked hot, but that wasn’t something she should be thinking about right now. Catra left without saying anything, leaving the blonde to finish the work by herself.

Adora could only laugh at her misfortune. She decided she needed to give Catra time to cool off, but could only hope it wouldn’t take long - she wanted her back, whether it be as a friend or something more.

the rhythm is driving me wild

Chapter Summary

While wanting to unwind, Catra meets a familiar face.

Chapter Notes

i managed to update in five days! my new record.
this is dedicated to nita, because she really helped me get through this chapter.

title from my lucky day by doredos :)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Swimming has always been therapeutic for Catra. Once she got over her fear of water in the middle of her junior year of High School, she had invested in swimming classes and it turned out that she was the fastest swimmer at their school, earning her the position of team captain quite quickly. There, she met a ton of people — some better than others — and finally got rid of all the rumors around the school, like that she was only good for cheerleading or that she couldn't do any *normal* sports. It felt good back then, but swimming competitively — while great — wasn't her favorite thing. Floating was. She could think and not be interrupted most of the time. It felt *great.*

After her one-sided, though she'd never admit it, argument with Adora, she was in need of a getaway — and what better way to do that than letting out some steam at the swimming centre. Since it was late afternoon, not many people would be there, Catra assumed. And she was right.

Once she got to the centre, Catra was greeted by a familiar face. She almost had to do a double take, just to make sure she was seeing things right.

“DT, what are you doing here? The fuck?” Catra asked, confused. Last time she saw them, they were off to The Wastes, a University known for its swimming program; and suddenly, they were here, in Etheria. At the BMU swimming centre, for some unknown reason.

“Oh, kitten, hello!” they waved their hand at her, while sporting that creepy smile they always had. It was oddly comforting, though. “Wasn’t expecting to see you here.”

Catra rolled her eyes. “What do you mean you weren’t? You knew I was going to BMU, DT, don’t act innocent,” she sighed. “The question is, what are you doing here?”

DT, or fully Double Trouble — they never told anyone their name, and their previous coach didn’t use their names anyway, so she had no way to find out — just smirked. “I transferred. Couldn’t keep myself away from you and your attractive personality,” they said, winking.

“Cut the crap,” she’s had enough of their playing; Catra knew all their tactics from the year they spent on one team. “While we might be friends, we both know you never liked my *attractive* personality. What are you *really* doing here?”

They just took a deep breath and looked behind the glass doors, at the pool area that was completely empty. “Wanna go for a swim? I’ll fill you in,” with that, they started heading towards the changing room. “Oh, and I know something happened, kitten. You have that look in your eyes that shows me how distressed you are. C’mon, before I tell you anything, you have to talk to me.”

She just followed after them. It’s not like Catra had any say in this; plus, she was actually curious about what the other person wanted to tell her. She also just wanted to catch up with an old friend.

After quietly changing into their swimwear, they both went out to the pool area. It was still empty, which made Catra really happy —

she didn’t like baring her emotions in public, even if she trusted DT. In silence, Catra made her way into the pool and laid down on her back, while her ex-teammate sat on the edge near her, dangling their feet above the water level, which was pretty low that day.

“So, Cathrina. What’s got your panties in a twist? Was it your mother? Maybe your new roommate! Oh, or did Lonnie call you up again? So many possibilities!”

Fuck, i forgot how much of a theatre kid they were.

“DT, calm down, you look like a kid that just managed to get their parents to take them to an amusement park,” Catra laughed softly. Throughout the year of their friendship, she managed to soften up to them enough to know there wasn’t any malice behind their words. “Also, you know she’s dead. And I don’t want anything to do with Lonnie after our rough break-up.”

DT just looked at her knowingly and smirked. “So, your roommate then? I’d like to assume you’ve either had a case of gay panic or you made a fool out of yourself, but please feel free to correct me.”

Catra, instead of replying, just stared at the ceiling, thinking. Seeing Adora again surprised her, but she wouldn’t say she had a moment of *gay panic* , unless the moment when she was checking out her childhood friend’s muscles counts.

If she wasn’t before, she was definitely panicking now. She needed to get away NOW. Fuck talking about why DT was there, she couldn’t stay there longer.

In one swift motion, she rolled onto her stomach and swam away from her friend. DT just looked at her with a troubled expression, clearly worried. They didn’t like it when the latina just… closed off; they thought she had worked on it with her previous therapist, but apparently it’s hard to get rid of such habits. All DT could do was watch it happen, so that’s what they did.

Meanwhile, Catra did what she could best — she drowned out all her thoughts and focused on swimming. *It's gonna be a good practice before both swimming practice and cheer practice* , she decided.

And maybe, just maybe, after this she'll have the strength to actually talk to Adora without lashing out.

She didn't.

It's been two weeks since their little fight, and they haven't spoken to each other. At least, not really. They said hello and good night, and asked about stuff like groceries (since neither of them really liked any of the restaurants near their building, they both decided that it'd be better to make their own meals most of the time). Besides that, they've been busy enough with settling in that they didn't even have time to think about talking to the other. Then, their classes started and that meant even less time to spend in each other's presence.

Catra looked around the empty room. She was sitting on her bed, munching on some jelly — which, her coaches would probably kill her for doing — and working on a sketch for one of her classes. Being a double major, while fun on paper, was exhausting and meant a lot more work for her to do; whatever possessed her to do that, while also being on the cheer and swimming teams, should just get out. Oh wait, *she* already did.

She *giggled.* Thinking about her foster mother's antics and how she always had to make sure Catra was on top of her classes while also doing a lot of extra-curriculum stuff made her *laugh* . Shyanne thought she'd look good with a daughter that was pretty much a perfect example of a renaissance person, but with that she drove Cathrina into a long term therapy, which she just had gotten out of few weeks earlier. It took a toll on her.

While Catra really learned to love studying, being an art *and* politics major was already kicking her butt, but she wasn't going to give up. She was stubborn like that, plus being considered one of the smartest people ever in her classes was nice. The attention was nice, if you don't count the jealous looks she got, even though it's only been a week and a half since the classes started. Catra still couldn't stand them.

Literally, all you have to do is study to have the same knowledge.

After another unsuccessful try to focus, Catra ripped another page from her sketchbook with her sharp, black nails and *growled* . She was already stressed enough from her cheer practice, she didn't need another problem on her mind.

It's just like coach said, you need to learn to calm down and compromise to be a good captain.

It annoyed her to no end. She was already offered the position of cheer captain — mainly because the previous captain graduated last year, some marine biology major — but she was still thinking about it, even though coach Starla was pretty set on it.

Starla, what a ridiculous name. It suits her, though, with her glittery look.

Catra really needed to get her mind off of things. She looked at the clock and noticed that it was only eight in the evening. Adora said she'd be back by nine, so she decided to get out of the stuffy dorm and grab some dinner in one of the many restaurants on

campus. She quickly went into the bathroom and looked into the mirror.

She didn't look half bad — she had a grey tank top on and some grey sweatpants. She quickly put her long, brown hair in a high ponytail and left to retrieve one of Adora's soccer jackets. While Catra would never admit it, not even to Adora, wearing her roommates jackets made her feel safe. It's not like Adora knew anyway, Catra was great at hiding it; or so she thought. She'd never find out that everytime her blonde friend found one of her jackets missing, she'd just smile softly to herself and leave it alone, too afraid to mention it.

After putting one of her credit cards securely in one of the pockets of the huge jacket, she left the dorm and locked it. She tucked her hands tightly into the pockets, mindful of the card, of the clothing that was ready to eat her alive with how huge on her it was and went off in the direction of school's library, where she knew one of the restaurants her best friend — Scorpia — and her girlfriend frequented was.

Adora was tired. It's been a long day of classes and soccer practice, but here she was. With her friends.

"Hey, 'Dora, do you mind throwing this out? Thanks," Glimmer asked, while laying on the blanket they set up in the park, her head in Bow's lap, as she handed her an empty water bottle. Adora got up grudgingly from her place in front of them and went to find the nearest trash can.

Glimmer, Bow and her had decided to go and relax together, mainly because the stress of their classes was getting to them. They had found a nice spot in the park — which, luckily was

almost completely empty — near campus and laid down their blanket there. Bow, the most caring person Adora has ever met, also brought them some snacks, so they wouldn't get hungry. An actual *angel* .

She looked around and headed to the nearest dumping area after locating it. She was dressed in a white BMU hoodie and some black leggins. Adora didn't bother dressing up, since her friends already had seen her at her worst — they loved her no matter what. Plus, they were there to relax, so what would be the point of looking like she was about to go on a catwalk?

After throwing out the bottle, she ran back to her friends, not wanting to leave them alone for long, because *god knows* what these two could do if left to themselves for too long. Adora shuddered at the thought. *Nope, don't wanna find out.*

"Hey, we should probably start heading back, it's getting late," exclaimed Bow as soon as she got there. She looked at her watch — it was a bit past eight thirty in the evening.

"You're right. I have an eight a.m. class tomorrow that I don't wanna be late for," Glimmer sighed while getting up. Bow quickly hid the blanket in his bag and, after a moment of cleaning up, they were done.

"Okay, I'll text you guys when I get back to my dorm. See you!" Adora said, hugged them both and started jogging back to her building.

"Bye, Adora!"

While going back to their dorm, Adora thought about texting Catra.

Should I tell her that I'll be back soon, or is that too domestic? Too friendly? Ugh, stupid feelings and stupid busy schedules.

She quickly dismissed the thought. Adora didn't need to let her know when she'll back, it's not like they were close or anything — no matter how much she wanted it.

Adora came to a quick stop in front of a restaurant near building four, which was on the other side of the campus. *Great, I got lost while thinking about Catra. Ugh.* She looked inside and noticed that it was mostly empty, except for a few college students. *Ah, fuck it, let's go in. I've got some spare money and I need to eat something either way.*

The door opened without a hitch and Adora was glad; she hated the sound of unoiled doors — it sent shivers down her spine, like something from a horror movie. She quickly moved towards the seating area, when something — or rather, someone — caught her attention. Sitting at one of the tables was Catra, dressed in some grey sweatpants and *her jacket.* Adora couldn't help the blush that appeared on her cheeks. While she knew her roommate was stealing her jackets, she never caught her red handed; and she wished she didn't, because *oh god* she looked so *fucking* hot. Adora couldn't look away and didn't notice, when the brown haired girl's eyes caught hers. Catra couldn't believe how *soft* Adora's eyes looked while looking at her, as if she was some kind of ethereal being. Both of them were speechless for two different reasons.

After finally snapping out of her stance, Adora headed over to where Catra was seated, earning her an eye roll from the other girl. She ignored her and sat at the seat opposite her, smirking.

"So that's where my jacket went, huh?"

Catra sighed. “Stop smirking, idiot. It’s not a good look for you,” she lied, sipping on some juice.

Adora just gave her a challenging look, clearly knowing that the other girl wasn’t telling the truth. “Yeah, sure. Did you order anything?”

The latina just pointed at her drink with a raised eyebrow.

“Ugh! You know I meant food,” the blonde said with a pout now visible on her face. Catra let out a sigh and shook her head.

“No, I haven’t ordered anything yet,” she said, and after moment of thought added: “Do you wanna eat something? My treat.”

Adora looked at her bewildered. *Why would she offer to buy me dinner?* “Uh, yes! Sure!” she said nervously, visibly sweating out of a sudden. Catra just giggled quietly, leaving any comments she had to herself. Besides, Adora looked adorable like that, though she’d never admit it.

A few minutes after ordering food, a waitress came to them with their food and set it in front of them, but not without winking at Catra and slipping a piece of paper on her side of the table. It didn’t go unnoticed by neither of the girls, yet they both failed to comment on it, eating their food in an uncomfortable silence.

Inside, Adora was fuming. *Who did that woman think she was, winking at Catra like that and giving her her number? Can’t she see that Catra’s here with me? Heck, she’s even wearing a jacket with* ***my*** *name on it!*

She was jealous. Obviously; there was no denying it on her part. She wished she could as shamelessly flirt with her roommate as the waitress just did. Adora kept eating her food, thinking about ways to start a conversation, when her thoughts got interrupted.

“Hey, I just wanted to say… I’m sorry for what happened on move-in day. I thought I was over everything, but clearly I wasn’t,” Catra let out a soft, quiet laugh; Adora’s heart almost

stopped beating. “And… don’t worry about this,” she picked up the number from the waitress. “I’m throwing it out when we get out of here. It’s not like I’m interested in anyone else other than you, baby,” she ended her monologue with a wink, and went back to eating her food smirking.

Adora was pretty much short circuiting. Nothing new near Catra, though.

Did she just call me baby and flirted with me. I can’t do this anymore — please someone end my suffering, this is too much.

For the next ten minutes, Adora sat looking at Catra with her mouth hanging open, while the other tried to ignore the staring, laughing quietly inside, and was finishing her meal.

After another minute of silence, Catra finally spoke up. “Are you gonna finish your food, or am I paying for air?”

Clearly surprised, Adora jumped in her seat, gaining her attention of the other people in the restaurant. She quickly got herself composed and an awkward smile crept onto her face. “Uh, yeah, I’ll eat it. Just… thanks,” and with that, she started stuffing her face with food, just so she could finish eating as fast as possible.

“What are you thanking me for?” Catra asked, genuinely confused.

“For, y’know. Being the bigger person. Apologizing,” Adora managed to get out of her, while taking quick breaks for breathing.

Catra just looked at her like she grew another head. “Well, yeah. That’s what good people do, you should get that through your thick skull.”

Adora, dizzy after eating too much, didn’t have much energy to reply. “Well, that waitress should get through her thick skull that you’re never going out with her,” she mumbled out.

“Oh yeah? I mean, I already told you I wouldn’t, but why wouldn’t I, really?” Catra got up from her seat and stood above Adora, somehow not bringing them attention from other tables. “It’s not like you owe me, or anything. I can go out with anyone I want, really.”

The blonde looked up at her, something *possessive* flashing through her eyes. “Yeah, you can. Doesn’t mean I have to like it,” with that, she stood up, meeting the other girl eye to eye, their noses barely touching. Catra took a sharp breath, her pupils dilating and landing on the other girls’ lips. Adora licked her lips, but neither of them were brave enough to actually lean in. Their moment was quickly interrupted by the newcomers to the restaurant.

“But, my dear Mermista! They have such a fine menu here, you have to check it out!” yelled Sea Hawk — whose real name was unknown to everyone besides Mermista — when he and his girlfriend came into the restaurant, making both Adora and Catra jump away from each other, sending the former to fall down on the seating area and the latter down onto the floor.

“Ugh, yeah, whatever. As long as you won’t ask to pay for me again,” Mermista said, taking the closest empty table she could find.

Catra and Adora, after coming to their senses, looked at each other wide-eyed. The blonde quickly got up from the seat and reached out a hand to help her childhood friend get up. The girl took Adora’s hand and dusted herself off. They stayed in comfortable silence, just looking at each other, when they got interrupted again, by the same waitress that served them earlier.

“Hello! I see that you’re finished with eating,” she said, looking directly at Catra and completely ignoring that Adora was even there. “I can offer you a *special* dessert though, cutie,” she winked at the latina, which made the girl in question *really* uncomfortable.

Meanwhile, Adora herself was fuming again. *Did she really not see what we've been up to before? Just what kind of restaurant is this?* She decided to take action herself and not let Catra suffer alone.

"Hey, miss," she quickly positioned herself behind Catra, wrapping her arms around the smaller woman's form and putting her hands into her jacket's pockets. Adora could feel the other girl stiffen up, but quickly relax after the blonde put her head on her shoulder. "She's kind of taken, if you haven't noticed. So I'd really appreciate if you could, I don't know, just take the payment and go serve a different client?" she finished, sending a death glare to the waitress.

Catra swiftly — well, as swiftly as she could with Adora's hands in the pockets — whipped out her credit card to the waitress' awaiting card reader. The woman's face was as red as tomato from embarrassment as she swiped the card and quickly ran away to what they could only assume was a break room.

The girls giggled. This wasn't the first time they pretended to be dating, it had happened a lot during their first two years of High School, when some guys would hit on them, despite them both being out. This time, though, it felt *different* , like there was something more to be said. Ignoring the feeling of something burning inside her, Adora quickly got herself detached from Catra and instead opted for leaving her hand free for the other girl to take. The brown haired girl instantly took it, and they both walked out of the restaurant with wide smiles on their faces, hand in hand.

They walked towards their building in comfortable silence. None of the girls really wanted to break it — it's been a long time since

they've been *this* close — and listening to the birds chirping with the sun fading out in the background was enough for them. Soft smiles visible on their faces, they weren't in a rush to get to their destination. Even though they knew they wouldn't part — they were roommates, after all — there was something different about talking a walk than being stuffed in their dorm. It gave them air and time to think.

Suddenly, Adora's phone pinged inside her hoodie, disturbing their silence. They came to a halt and the blonde took a look at her companion's face. Catra's eyes didn't have anything malicious in them, they were as soft as she remembered them being when they were just kids; her muscles were relaxed, forming a small smile on her face, which was also adorned by freckles. With the golden lightning from the fading sun, Catra looked like a goddess. Adora never felt more at peace.

She quickly took out her phone and checked her notification. *Wow, it's already almost ten p.m.* , Adora noted. Clicking on the pop-up, she was met with a message about a random practice that was scheduled in the morning of the next day. She rolled her eyes dismissing the notification and locking her phone before putting it in her pocket again.

Looking back at Catra, she was met with curious eyes. The girl's hand was still firmly intertwined with hers, to Adora's comfort. "Was that something important?" the latina asked, being careful not to pry too much.

Adora smiled softly, running her thumb over the other's hand. "Just some practice being scheduled, nothing important. C'mon, let's go," giving Catra's hand a small tug, they continued their journey back home in silence.

Neither of them wanted to talk just yet. They could do it the next day. For now, they had their peace and quiet and, most importantly, each other. That's all both Catra and Adora could've asked for.

Chapter End Notes

okay i know this is shorter than the first chap, but i didn't wanna prelong this. also, it has way more catradora in it which makes it automatically better.

also i'd like to say that i wrote like 4/5 of this in one day and i have no memory of it. the only thing i remember is having catra call adora baby because of AJ.

kudos & comments are appreciated <3

End Notes

uhh yeah this was supposed to be a chapter and a half but i felt weird ending it at like 4k words :// yeah idk when i'll update next since i have some plans this week but i'll try to update this in less than two weeks.. probably

you can find me on twitter (catravol) for any updates too ^^ this will probably have like.. 5/6 chapters at most? i don't like making my works super long because i get bored quickly oops

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!